

The StraightLine Insight Note — June 2026

This month's Insight Note draws from four StraightLine proof pieces: Order Fulfilment, Inventory Confidence, ERP versus Excel/warehouse reality, and Improved Inventory Management.

When the report still needs a second check

Most businesses do not have a reporting problem because they lack data.

They have a reporting clarity problem because the data they already have is not always clear enough to trust, explain, or act on.

That was the thread running through June's StraightLine case studies.

Order fulfilment.

Inventory confidence.

ERP versus Excel.

Stock availability.

Cancellation exposure.

Warehouse routing.

Decision-ready reporting.

Different datasets. Different business questions. Same underlying issue.

The system may hold the information.

The report may refresh.

The dashboard may look tidy.

The spreadsheet may reconcile at headline level.

But if people still need to check something else before they trust the number, the business has not reached decision-ready reporting yet.

It has reached reporting with caution attached.

What I noticed this month

June kept returning to one practical question:

Can people trust the report enough to make the next decision from it?

That sounds simple, but it sits at the heart of many ERP, MRP, inventory and operational reporting problems.

A stock report may show quantity, but not whether the stock can safely be promised.

An order report may show fulfilment status, but not whether the value is properly supported.

A cancellation report may show lost revenue, but not whether routing, lead time or warehouse selection helped create the exposure.

A reconciliation may look acceptable at headline level, but still leave product/location exceptions that need proper review.

This is where reporting clarity matters.

Because the report does not only need to show what happened.

It needs to show what the business can safely do next.

The problem underneath

A report can be technically correct and still not be useful enough.

That is the uncomfortable part.

The ERP may be answering one question while the warehouse, sales team, finance team or operations manager needs another.

For example:

- **“How much stock exists?”** is not the same as **“How much stock can we promise?”**
- **“Has the order been delivered?”** is not the same as **“Does the payment position support the recorded order value?”**
- **“What was ordered?”** is not the same as **“What converted into actual revenue, shipped activity and operational value?”**
- **“Does the closing stock broadly reconcile?”** is not the same as **“Which product/location checks still need review?”**

That gap is where workarounds begin.

People export data.

They maintain their own spreadsheet.

They ask someone in the warehouse.

They check the order history.

They look at the bin.

They wait until someone more experienced confirms the position.

Those checks are not necessarily a weakness.

Often, they are the reason the business keeps moving.

But when manual checking becomes the hidden layer behind every report, management may not see where trust is being lost.

The June proof theme

The June case studies showed the same reporting trust issue from several angles.

1. Order fulfilment: status is not enough

Order fulfilment reporting can look useful when it shows orders by status: delivered, shipped, cancelled, pending, unavailable or processing. But order status alone does not tell the full business story.

34.40M Recorded Order Value	24.00M Recorded Payment Value	-10.41M Net Payment Position	69.75% Payment Coverage
21.33M Underpaid Exposure	10.92M Overpaid Exposure	20.98M Delivered Orders Underpaid	495.94K Paid Value Not Delivered

When payment values were included, the issue was no longer just:

“What happened to the order?”

It became:

“Does the recorded payment position support the order value we are reporting?”

That is a different level of reporting; it moves the conversation from activity to control.

2. Inventory confidence: headline reconciliation can hide review work

The Inventory Confidence case showed why a good-looking headline number is not always enough.

Opening stock, closing stock, purchases and sales were available as separate reports. At top level, the movement almost reconciled. That could easily make the position look broadly acceptable. But when the data was reviewed by product and location, the work became more practical.

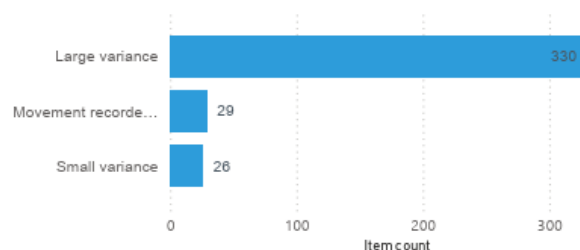
Most checks reconciled. Some needed review. The important shift was not simply finding a difference. It was identifying where the review should start and what evidence was needed before management could trust the number.

Summary of Stock Counts and Net Transactions Recorded

4.22M Opening stock quantity 2016	4.89M Closing stock quantity 2016	4.90M Expected Closing Stock	-2.88K Difference to Review
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Product/location checks needing review

2.76K product/location checks matched expected movement; 385 needed review



That changed the business question from:

“Is the stock figure close enough?”

to:

“Which product/location checks need review, and what assumptions must be confirmed before this report is safe to use?”

The review plan gives the business somewhere sensible to look next, not just a number.

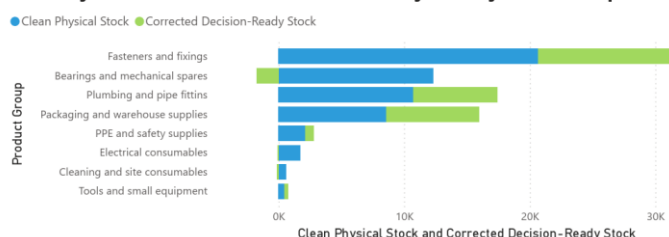
3. ERP versus warehouse reality: available is not always promise-ready

The ERP versus warehouse case made the trust gap especially visible.

At management level, the ERP stock report suggested that stock was available. But the warehouse view showed a more complicated position.

When stock is miscounted, in unexpected locations, misplaced or not passed through quality checks, a physical stock number might not mean decision-ready or available stock.

Clean Physical Stock and Corrected Decision-Ready Stock by Product Group



The issue was not whether stock existed. The issue was whether the stock was usable, available, and safe to promise.

For a business, the better question is: **“Does the report show the difference between stock that exists and stock the business can act on?”**

4. Inventory management: better data made the next question visible

The improved Inventory Management case started with a dataset that showed a large gap between ordered revenue and actual revenue. That was useful, but incomplete.

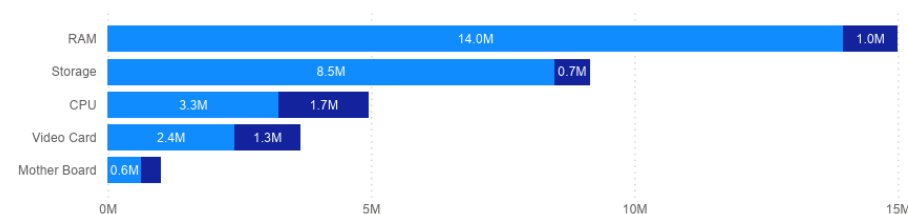
The first analysis could show cancellation exposure. It could show that ordered value did not fully translate into realised operational value. It could show pressure around stock, demand and revenue. But it could not fully explain why.

Once the dataset was improved with fulfilment lead time, shipping cost, default warehouse and actual shipping warehouse fields, the analysis became more useful.

Better data did not remove the cancellation problem. It made the next operational question visible.

Total Cancelled Revenue & Actual Profit by Product Category

● Revenue Cancelled ● Actual Profit



Customer	# Orders	Order Date	orderstatus	Total Revenue	Total Profit	% Shipping Cost on Ordered Value	Fulfilment Lead Time
2607	1	17 February 2016	Canceled	11,648,820.00	412,730.00	0.13%	21
2606	1	21 February 2017	Pending	2,166,460.00	292,338.00	0.41%	375
2563	1	26 May 2016	Shipped	1,054,301.68	0.00	0.58%	16
2642	1	17 February 2016	Shipped	1,047,178.02	0.00	0.40%	8
2659	1	17 March 2017	Pending	1,032,930.70	0.00	2.91%	300
2653	1	28 October 2015	Canceled	1,004,436.06	0.00	0.49%	35
2554	1	29 November 2016	Pending	990,188.74	0.00	0.84%	10
2567	1	16 August 2016	Shipped	983,065.08	0.00	1.67%	30
2556	1	27 September 2017	Shipped	975,941.42	0.00	0.44%	21
2660	1	21 February 2017	Shipped	954,570.44	0.00	1.23%	3
2620	1	20 February 2017	Shipped	929,670.00	264,670.00	0.54%	10
Total	400			78,999,986.12	7,034,865.10	1.96%	

It became possible to ask better operational questions:

- Were cancellations connected to fulfilment route?
- Did non-default warehouse use suggest stock allocation issues?
- Were long lead times creating avoidable customer risk?
- Were certain product categories carrying more cancellation exposure?
- Did shipping cost or warehouse location help explain part of the pattern?
- Were some outstanding orders distorting fulfilment lead-time measures?

The improved dataset did not remove the cancellation problem. It made the next operational question visible.

That is often the real value of better reporting: not instant certainty but a clearer path to the next useful decision.

The pattern behind the month

Across the June work, the same pattern appeared again and again.

1. The business has data.
2. The report gives an answer.
3. The answer may not be wrong.
4. But the decision still needs more context.
5. People compensate manually.
6. The workaround becomes normal.
7. The real reporting gap becomes harder to see.

This is why “we already have reports” is not always the same as “we have reporting confidence”.

The question is not whether a report exists.

The question is whether the report is clear enough to support the decision people are actually trying to make.

One practical check

Pick one report that people use regularly.

It might be:

- a stock availability report;
- an MRP output;
- an order fulfilment report;
- a purchasing report;
- a warehouse report;
- a finance reconciliation;
- an Excel export from the ERP;
- a dashboard used in management meetings.

Then ask:

What does someone still check before they trust this report?

That one question usually reveals something useful.

It may show a missing definition.

It may show a timing issue.

It may show a training gap.

It may show an exception category that is not visible.

It may show that Excel is carrying business logic the ERP report does not explain.

It may show that the report answers the system question, but not the operational decision.

This is where reporting improvement often starts.

Not always with a bigger dashboard.

With a clearer understanding of where confidence breaks.

What better reporting should do

A useful report should help the business separate three things:

1. **What the system says**
2. **What the team knows**
3. **What the decision needs**

When those three things are aligned, reporting becomes decision support.

When they are not, the business may still function, but only because experienced people are quietly carrying the gaps.

That knowledge is valuable.

It should not live only in someone’s head, someone’s inbox, or the spreadsheet they keep open beside the ERP.

Good reporting does not replace operational judgement.

It gives that judgement somewhere visible to live.

What SMEs can do next

For SMEs dealing with ERP, MRP, inventory, fulfilment or reporting uncertainty, the first step does not need to be a major transformation project.

A focused reporting clarity review may be enough to start.

That review should ask:

- What decision is this report meant to support?
- What does the report include and exclude?
- Which figures are still checked manually?
- Where does Excel take over from the ERP?
- Which exceptions are hidden or unclear?
- Are stock status, order status, warehouse location, timing and corrections visible?
- Do different teams use the same definition of available, fulfilled, committed, cancelled or decision-ready?
- What would make the report safer to use without needing a second check?

The aim is not to criticise the system or the team.

The aim is to find the point where reporting stops being merely available and starts becoming genuinely useful.

Question for the month

Which report in your business still needs a second check before people feel safe using it?

And what does that second check reveal?

That answer may be where the real reporting work starts.

The StraightLine view

This month's case studies were not only about dashboards.

They were about trust.

ERP, MRP, inventory and fulfilment reports only become valuable when people understand what the numbers mean, what they do not mean, and what decision they can safely support.

A dashboard can show more data.

Decision support shows what matters next.

Sometimes the first sign of a reporting problem is not a missing report.

It is the spreadsheet people keep open beside it.

How StraightLine Data & Training can help

StraightLine Data & Training helps SMEs turn messy operational data, ERP outputs, Excel checks and reporting uncertainty into clearer decisions, practical dashboards and more confident system use.

If your reports look acceptable but your teams still rely on manual checks, I can help you identify where reporting confidence is being lost and what needs to be clarified first.

That might mean:

- reviewing an ERP or MRP report;
- comparing dashboard output with operational reality;
- identifying where Excel workarounds are carrying hidden logic;
- creating an exception view;
- improving stock, order, fulfilment or inventory reporting;
- helping teams understand what a report can safely be used for.

If the report exists but the decision still feels uncertain, that is exactly the kind of gap worth reviewing.